Building collapse

Bill is the engineering manager at a large construction company. To do a favor for a friend, he instructs his subordinate, Bob, to hire his friend's daughter, Judy, as an engineering intern. Bob, in order to gain favor with his boss, assigns Judy to do the design calculations on a crucial part of an important building project. Three months after the completion of the project, part of the building collapses, killing three people and injuring several dozen more. An investigation by the regulatory agency determines that the problem was faulty calculations done by Judy.

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1. Identifying Ethical Issues

-Should Bill's friend ask Bill the favor to directly hire Judy?

-Should Bill do the favor for his friend to directly hire Judy? ?

-Should Bill instruct his subordinate Bob to hire Judy?

-Should Bob hire Judy just to satisfy Bill? ?

-Should Bob follow all of Bill's instructions? ? ?

-Should Bob gain Bill's favor beyond his own work? ?

-Should Bob assign Judy, an intern, to an important job?

-Should Judy accept the design calculation job as an intern?

-Should Judy make a calculation mistake in design of crucial part?

-Should the company make sure the building pass safety test? ?

Some of these ethical issues are based on assumption about what happened. ~~[illegible]~~ ~~[illegible]~~ ~~[illegible]~~ ~~[illegible]~~

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For 1-4, an engineer should be evaluated as qualified before being hired. And specially for 3-4, Bob may not have the right to decide whom to hire. For 5-6, an employee doesn't need to satisfy his or her boss's personal favor. For 7-8, an engineer should not do a job which is beyond his or her ability, especially the crucial parts concerned to human death. For 9, an engineer should never make a product that can cause human death. For 10, even though the engineer has designed something unqualified, the company should have a second check and evaluate the safety of final building.

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2. Narrowing the focus

-Should Judy do the important design job which is beyond her ability and concerning to safety?

Because Judy's calculation mistake, directly caused collapse, and as an intern, Judy is not supposed to carry such an important job. Furthermore, Judy may not even be qualified as an engineer intern.

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We need recognizing the ethical issue yet.

We could be more if was yet

3. Determining Relevant Facts

-Bob is Bill's subordinate.

-Judy is the relative of Bill's friend.

-Bob is the one who directly hires Judy.

-Judy is hired as an engineer intern.

-Bob assigns Judy to do an important design calculation job.

-Judy makes a mistake in her calculation work.

-The mistake Judy made causes the collapse and human death and injury.

? Do we know this? We might have had to go through some kind of HR process

-Is Judy qualified to do such an important design calculation?

-Is an engineering intern allowed to do the crucial design calculation of a building?

-Does the company have a second check on the design safety of the building?

Good! We don't know this

4. Making reasonable assumptions

-Is Judy qualified to do such an important design calculation?

If the answer is no, then Bob's decision of assigning Judy to the calculation job is completely to please his boss. And the improper arrangement accounts for Judy's mistake. But, if the answer is yes, then the mistake is more of Judy's own professional problems.

-Is an engineering intern allowed to do the crucial design calculation of a building?

If the answer is no, then Bob's decision is against the regulation even if Judy is qualified. If there is no such regulation, then it's back to the first question.

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-Should the company have a second check on the design safety of the building?

If there is such regulation, then the division or person in charge of second check should also be responsible for the collapse. But if not, then the direct reason is only Judy's mistake.

5. Undertaking definitional clarification

Qualified – If we say an engineer is qualified for a job, it means he or she has the ability to do this job to a necessary standard.

Important – When we describe the job as important, it means this job will have great effect on the function and safety of the final product.

Safety – If we say a product is unsafe, it means that the product has the potential to cause harm to human life or even death.